

GO · VARIANT 1 OF 14

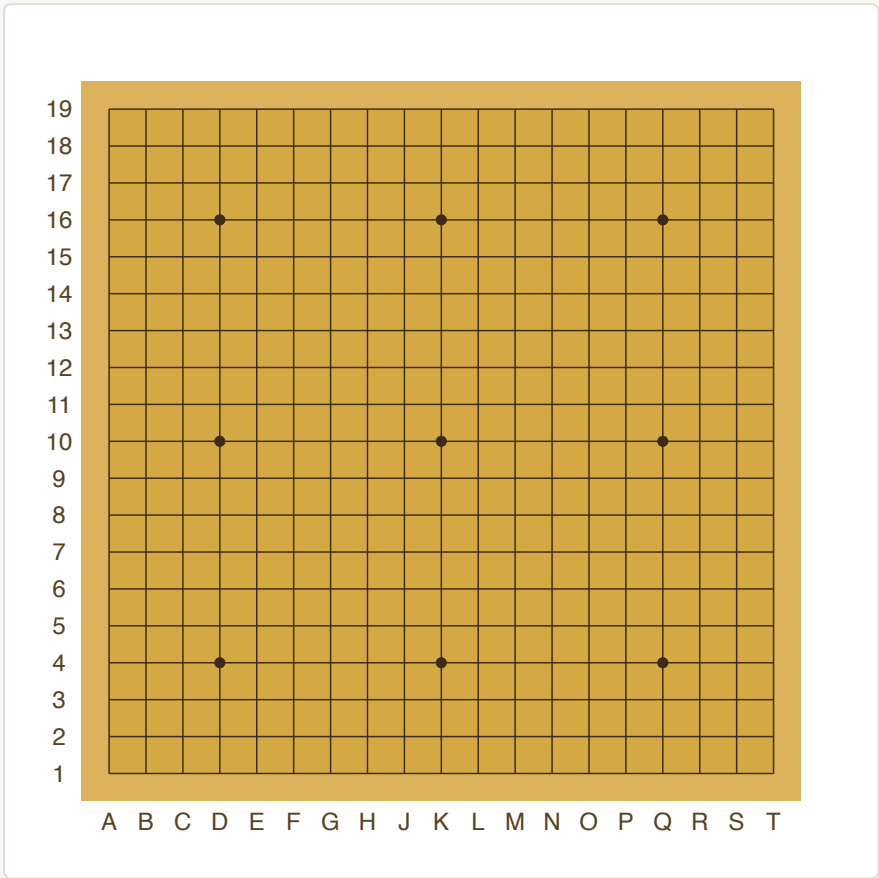
Standard Go (19×19)

19×19
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

STANDARD GO (19×19)

The full tournament game played on a 19×19 grid with 361 intersections. One fundamental rule — capture by surrounding — produces extraordinary strategic depth. Games last 60–180 minutes at tournament level.



Go — 19×19 board

COMPONENTS

ITEM	QTY	NOTES
Board	1	19×19 grid (361 intersections)
Black stones	181	Enough to cover slightly more than half the board
White stones	180	One fewer than Black (Black plays first)

SETUP

The board starts empty. Black plays first. Stones are placed on intersections (where lines cross), not inside squares.

RULES

Placement: On each turn, a player places one stone of their colour on any empty intersection, or passes.

Liberties and capture:

- ♦ An empty intersection adjacent to a stone (horizontally or vertically) is a liberty.
- ♦ Adjacent same-colour stones form a group and share liberties.
- ♦ A group with zero liberties is captured and removed from the board.
- ♦ A stone may be placed on a zero-liberty intersection if doing so captures opponent stones.

Ko rule: A move that returns the board to the immediately previous position is forbidden. If one player captures a single stone, the opponent must play elsewhere before recapturing.

Suicide: A move that would leave your own group with zero liberties without capturing any opponent stones is forbidden.

SCORING

The game ends when both players pass consecutively.

Area scoring (Chinese): Score = your stones on the board + empty intersections surrounded only by your stones.

Territory scoring (Japanese): Score = empty intersections you surround – your captured stones (prisoners).

Both methods produce the same winner in nearly all cases.

KOMI

White receives 6.5 points of compensation for moving second. The half-point prevents draws.

ATTRIBUTION

Traditional game originating in China approximately 4,000 years ago. Known as Weiqi (Chinese), Baduk (Korean), Igo (Japanese). Public domain. Rules standardised by the International Go Federation.

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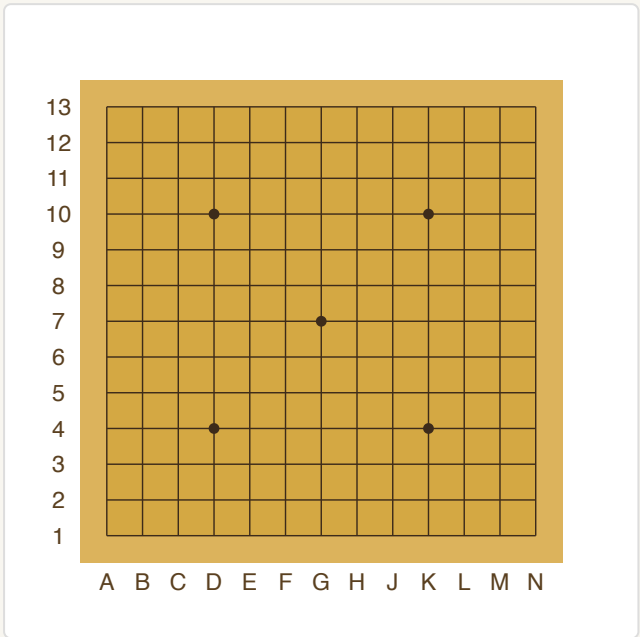
13×13 Go

13×13
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

13×13 GO

Standard Go rules on a 13×13 grid. The intermediate board bridges the tactical intensity of 9×9 with the strategic depth of 19×19. Games typically last 30–60 minutes. Used in some official tournament categories and widely played online.



Go — 13×13 board

SETUP

Same as standard Go. Board starts empty. Black plays first. Komi: 5.5 points for White.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply without modification. Placement, liberties, capture, ko, and suicide rules are identical.

DIFFERENCES FROM 19×19

- ♦ Fewer intersections (169 vs 361) means influence radiates further relative to board size.
- ♦ Opening theory is less developed, encouraging creative play.
- ♦ Corners and sides are proportionally larger relative to the centre.
- ♦ Games are decided more by fighting and reading than by large-scale framework building.

ATTRIBUTION

Standard board size recognised by all major Go federations. Public domain.

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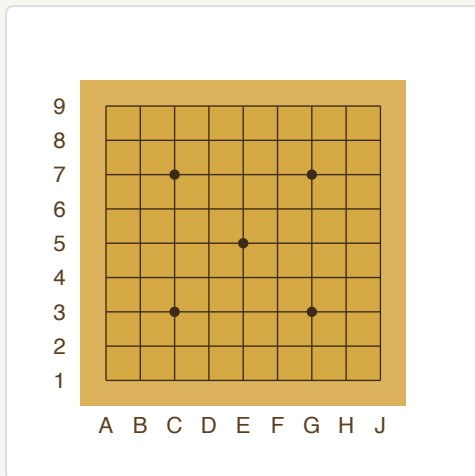
9×9 Go

9×9
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

9×9 GO

Standard Go rules on a 9×9 grid. The smallest standard board, ideal for beginners learning fundamentals and for quick tactical games between experienced players. Official tournament category in many federations. Games typically last 10–20 minutes.



Go — 9×9 board

SETUP

Same as standard Go. Board starts empty. Black plays first. Komi: 5.5 points for White.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply without modification.

DIFFERENCES FROM 19×19

- ♦ Only 81 intersections. Every stone immediately affects the whole board.
- ♦ No room for large-scale frameworks or moyo. Influence is purely local.
- ♦ Life-and-death reading is paramount. Groups live or die in direct combat.
- ♦ First-move advantage is smaller (hence lower komi).
- ♦ Games are often decided by a single fight. One mistake is usually fatal.

ATTRIBUTION

Standard board size recognised by all major Go federations. Public domain.

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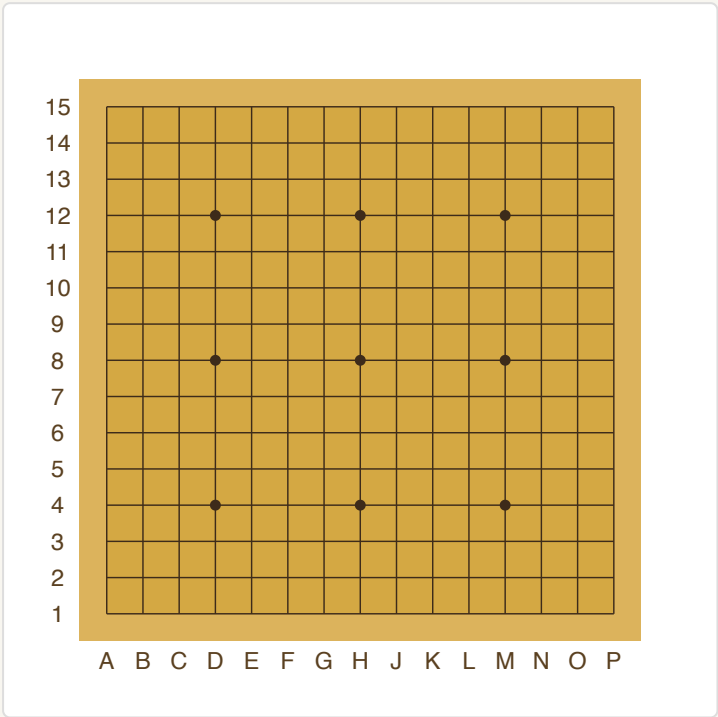
Gomoku

15×15
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

GOMOKU

Gomoku, also known as Five in a Row, is a two-player strategy board game. Players use black and white pieces, taking turns placing them on the intersections of horizontal and vertical lines on the board. The first player to form an unbroken line of five pieces horizontally, vertically, or diagonally wins the game.



Empty 15×15 board — Gomoku

Since 1899, when Japanese chess player Kuroi Iwa Ruiko proved that the original rules of Gomoku guaranteed a win for the first player, Gomoku has undergone continuous improvement. After decades of modifications, verifications, and further revisions, a version with added forbidden moves was developed. This version was publicly named Renju, and the rules were formalised in Japan. The original rules are still played and are referred to as “no-ban rules” or “free-style rules”.

SETUP

Board: 15×15 intersections. The game is also playable on a full 19×19 Go board using 15×15 of the intersecting lines.

Pieces: Black and white stones.

First move: Black plays first.

RULES

Players take turns placing one stone per turn on any empty intersection. Stones are never moved or captured after placement.

The first player to form an unbroken line of five pieces horizontally, vertically, or diagonally wins. In the Standard version, rows of more than five consecutive pieces do not count as a win.

TERMINOLOGY

- ♦ **Five in a Row:** Five consecutive pieces of the same colour in a horizontal, vertical, or diagonal line.
- ♦ **Open Four:** A row of four pieces with both ends open, allowing for two ways to form Five in a Row.
- ♦ **Closed Four:** A row of four pieces with only one end open, allowing for one way to form Five in a Row.
- ♦ **Open Three:** A formation that can become an Open Four, including both continuous and jump open threes. A jump open three has one piece separated but still within five spaces.
- ♦ **Overline:** A line of more than five consecutive pieces of the same colour.

ATTRIBUTION

Ancient Chinese placement game. Public domain. Origin: Japan, around 1905. Source: Murray 1951: 50.

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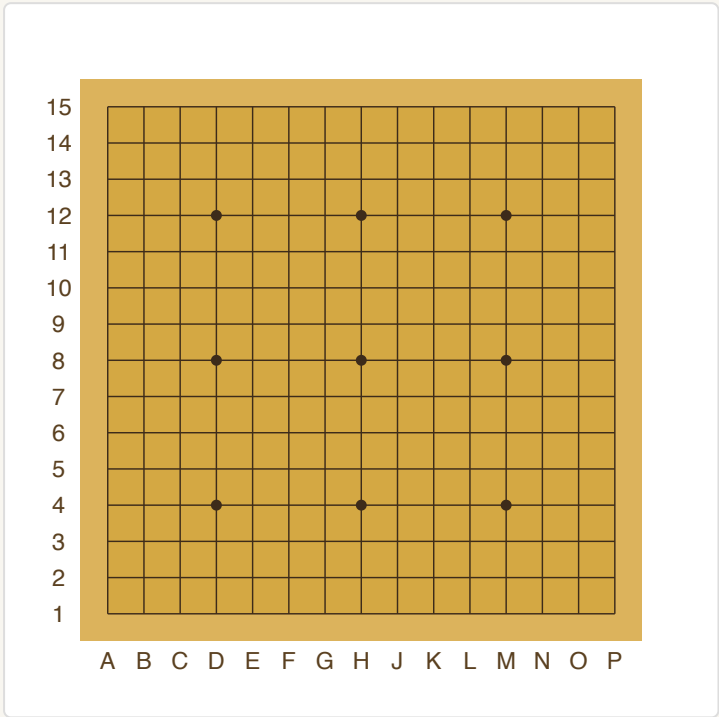
Ninuki-Renju

15×15
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

NINUKI-RENU

Ninuki-Renju is a Japanese placement game in the Gomoku family that adds custodial capture to the five-in-a-row objective. It is the direct historical precursor to Pente (1977); Pente's designer Gary Gabrel explicitly cites it as inspiration. The game was organised as a competitive sport in Japan by the Ninuki Renju Sha from 1923 to 1940.



Empty 15×15 board — Ninuki-Renju

SETUP

Board: 15×15.

Pieces: Black and white stones.

First move: Black plays first.

RULES

Players alternate placing one stone per turn on any empty intersection.

Capture: A pair of opponent stones may be captured by custodial capture: sandwiching exactly two opponent stones lengthwise between two of your own in a single move. Captured stones are removed from the board.

Win conditions: Either of the following wins the game:

- 1 Form exactly five stones in an unbroken row (horizontally, vertically, or diagonally).
- 2 Capture five pairs (ten stones total).

Overline: Six or more stones in a row does not win. The line is neutral and play continues.

Restrictions on Black: Black may not form a double-three (two simultaneous open lines of three) unless doing so is required to destroy an unperfect five (see below).

Unperfect five: If a player forms five in a row and their opponent immediately captures a pair across that line on the very next move, the five is nullified. It is called an unperfect five and play continues. The capture must come on the move immediately following the five.

Draw: If a player's fifth capture removes one stone from an opponent's six-in-a-row, leaving exactly five in a row, the game is a draw.

ATtribution

Japanese competitive game. Organised by the Ninuki Renju Sha, Japan, 1923-1940. Direct historical precursor to Pente (1977). Public domain. Sources: Renju International Federation (renju.se); Wikipedia (Pente article, Gomoku article).

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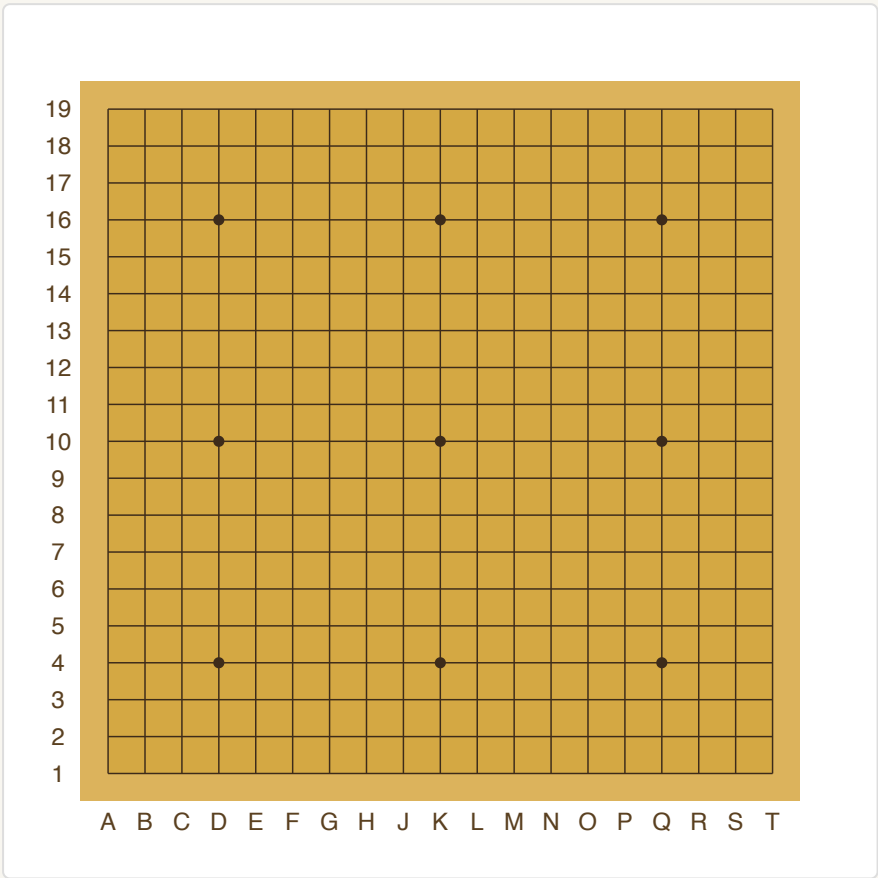
One-Colour Go

19×19
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

ONE-COLOUR GO

Both players use stones of the same colour. All other rules are unchanged. Players must remember which stones belong to whom. A referee (or agreed record) tracks ownership secretly. The ultimate memory and visualisation challenge.



One-Colour Go — standard board

SETUP

Standard board (any size). All stones are the same colour (traditionally all black or all white). A referee or written record tracks which stones belong to which player. Black plays first as normal.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply. The only change is visual: both players' stones look identical on the board.

- ♦ Captures still work normally: a group with zero liberties is removed regardless of appearance.
- ♦ Ko applies normally: the referee tracks the position.
- ♦ If a player attempts an illegal move (placing on an occupied intersection, violating ko, or suicide), the referee informs them and they must choose a different move.

PRACTICAL IMPLEMENTATION

- ♦ **With referee:** One person sits between players, marks ownership on a hidden diagram.
- ♦ **Online:** Software tracks ownership and displays an undifferentiated board to both players.
- ♦ **Training solo:** Play both sides using one colour. Strong professionals use this as a reading exercise.

STRATEGY

One-Colour Go rewards players who naturally visualise board positions without relying on colour cues. It exposes whether your reading is truly deep (based on understanding group structure) or shallow (based on pattern-matching colours). Strong professionals can play full 19×19 games this way. For most players, 9×9 is a challenging starting point.

ATTRIBUTION

Training variant used by professional Go players. Public domain. Source: Sensei's Library.

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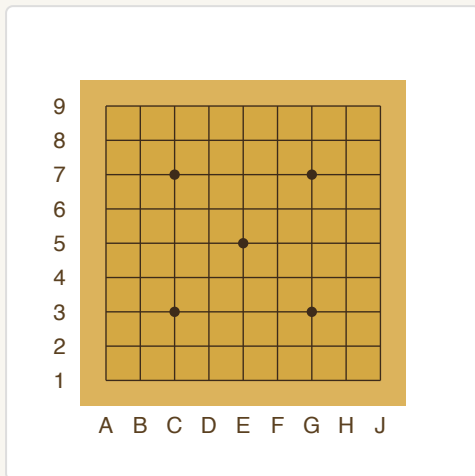
Phantom Go

9×9 or 13×13
BOARD

2 + referee
PLAYERS

PHANTOM GO

Fog-of-war Go. Players cannot see opponent stones. A referee mediates all moves and announces captures. Deduction replaces reading. Played on 9x9 or 13x13 boards.



Phantom Go — typically played on 9x9

SETUP

Equipment: Three boards are needed: one for each player and one for the referee. Players sit back-to-back so neither can see the other's board. The referee stands between them with the master board showing all stones.

Board size: Usually 9x9 or 13x13.

Stones: Standard Go stones. Black plays first.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply (placement, capture, ko, no suicide) with the following modifications:

- ♦ **Hidden information:** Players can only see their own stones. Opponent stones are invisible.
- ♦ **Turn structure:** A player places a stone on their own board. The referee checks legality on the master board. If legal, the referee copies it to the master board and announces the result. If illegal, the player tries again (it remains their turn).
- ♦ **Passing:** A player may pass. The referee announces passes to both players.

ANNOUNCEMENTS (COMMON RULES)

- ♦ **Illegal moves:** The referee says only “Illegal move” without stating why.
- ♦ **Captures:** When a capture occurs, the referee announces “Black/White has captured the following stones” and points out exactly which stones were captured to both players.
- ♦ **Atari:** The referee announces atari only if the stones were not already in atari before the move. The referee says “Black/White puts White/Black into atari” but does NOT say which specific stones are in atari.

ANNOUNCEMENTS (HAMBURG RULES)

The Hamburg variant differs in two ways:

- ♦ The referee **reveals why** a move is illegal (occupied by own stone, occupied by opponent stone, suicide, or ko) rather than just saying “Illegal move.”
- ♦ The referee does **NOT** point out which specific stones were captured (only announces the number).

This creates different deduction dynamics: you learn more from failed moves but less from opponent captures.

WIN CONDITION

Standard Go scoring applies. The game ends when both players pass consecutively. Territory or area scoring determines the winner.

STRATEGY

- ♦ Information is the scarcest resource. Every failed move attempt reveals something about the board state.
- ♦ Playing cautiously (avoiding illegal move attempts) preserves secrecy but risks falling behind.
- ♦ Captures are the primary source of confirmed information about opponent stone positions.
- ♦ On 9x9 boards, the reduced space makes deduction more tractable.

ATTRIBUTION

Variant with active competitive community. Source: Sensei’s Library (OPL 1.0).

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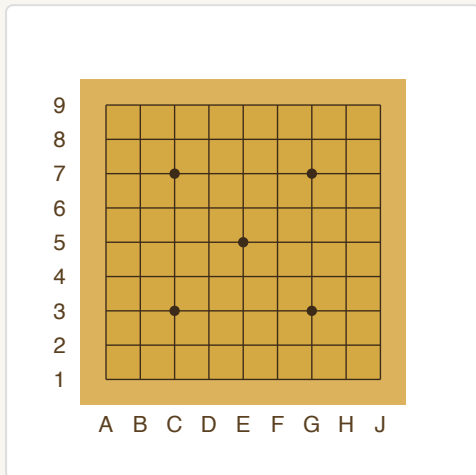
Capture Go

9×9
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

CAPTURE GO

The first player to capture any opponent stone wins immediately. No territory counting, no endgame, no passing. Also known as Atari Go. The universal introduction to Go for beginners, teaching the fundamental mechanics of liberties and capture without the complexity of territory evaluation.



Capture Go — typically played on 9×9

SETUP

Board: Any size. 9×9 is standard for Capture Go; 7×7 or 5×5 for absolute beginners.

Stones: Standard Go stones.

First move: Black plays first. No komi.

RULES

- ♦ **Placement:** Standard — one stone per turn on any empty intersection.
- ♦ **Liberties and groups:** Identical to standard Go.
- ♦ **Winning:** The first player to capture one or more opponent stones wins immediately. The game ends the moment a capture occurs.
- ♦ **No passing:** Players may not pass (the game must end in a capture, not a territory count).
- ♦ **Ko:** Standard ko rule applies.
- ♦ **Suicide:** Forbidden.

DRAWS

If the board fills completely with no captures (extremely rare on standard sizes), the game is a draw.

STRATEGY

Capture Go teaches the tactical fundamentals of Go: recognising atari (one liberty remaining), defending groups by extending liberties, attacking by reducing enemy liberties, and creating ladder (shicho) and net (geta) captures. Advanced Capture Go on 9×9 between experienced players becomes a tense dance of mutual threats where neither player wants to create the first vulnerability.

ATTRIBUTION

Teaching variant used worldwide. Public domain. Recommended by all major Go federations as an introductory format. Source: Sensei's Library.

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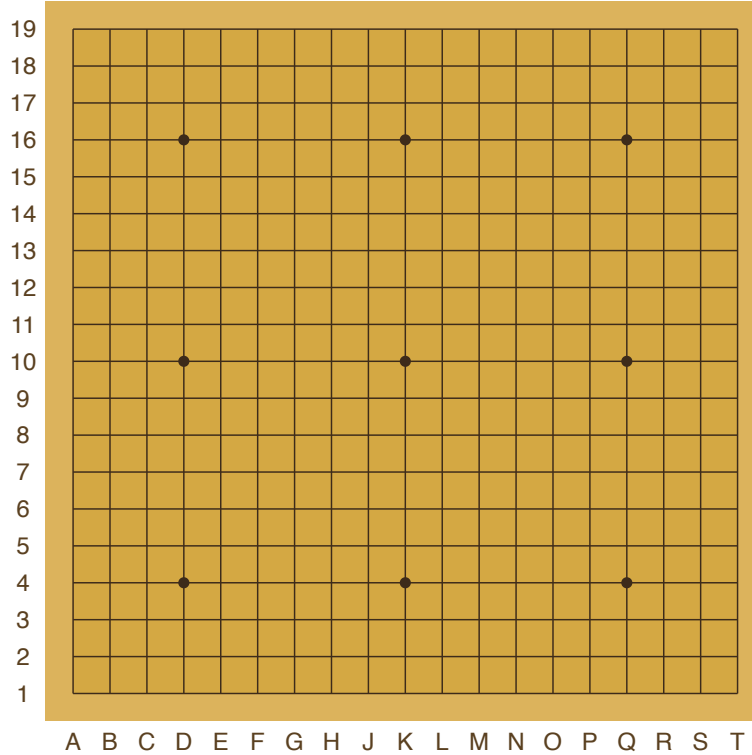
Rengo

19×19
BOARD

4–6
PLAYERS

RENGO

Team Go where two or three players per side alternate turns without consulting each other. Partners must infer each other's strategy purely from the stones played. Creates emergent cooperation and occasional hilarious miscommunication.



Rengo — standard board

SETUP

Teams: Two teams of 2 or 3 players each. Standard 19×19 board (or 13×13 for shorter games). Board starts empty.

Turn order: Players alternate in a fixed, repeating sequence. In 2v2: Black-1, White-1, Black-2, White-2, repeat. In 3v3: Black-1, White-1, Black-2, White-2, Black-3, White-3, repeat.

Komi: Standard (6.5 for 19×19).

RULES

All standard Go rules apply, with one addition:

- ♦ **No consultation:** Partners may not discuss strategy, signal, or communicate about the game in any way during play. Each player must independently decide their move.
- ♦ **Passing:** A player may pass on their turn as normal. Both members of a team must pass consecutively for that team to have passed.
- ♦ **Game end:** The game ends when all four (or six) players pass consecutively.

SCORING

Standard scoring applies. The team's combined territory is their score.

STRATEGY

Rengo rewards consistent, clear positional play over complex, deep reading. Your partner cannot see your 15-move sequence plan, so moves that make structural sense at a glance are more effective than subtle tactical tricks. The strongest Rengo players are those whose stones “explain themselves” — each move clearly communicates its purpose to a partner who shares Go understanding but not specific plans.

ATTRIBUTION

Traditional team format. Japanese term (). Public domain. Played at the European Go Congress and many club events.

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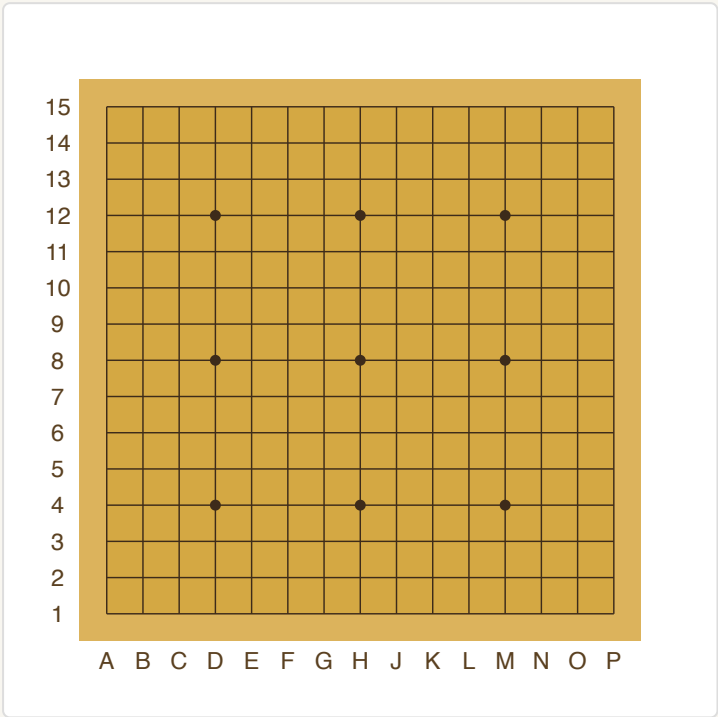
Renju

15×15
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

RENJU

Renju is a professional variant of Gomoku. It was named renju by Japanese journalist Ruikou Kuroiwa on December 6, 1899. The name “renju” means “connected pearls” in Japanese. The game is played with black and white stones on a 15×15 board. Renju weakens the first-player advantage for Black by adding special restrictions.



Empty 15×15 board — Renju

There are two key differences between Renju and Gomoku. First, Renju has forbidden moves to limit Black’s advantage. Second, Renju uses special opening rules to balance the starting positions of games.

SETUP

Board: 15×15. Black plays first.

Pieces: Black and white stones.

RULES

Players alternate placing one stone per turn on an empty intersection. Black plays first; stones alternate strictly by move order. Stones are never moved or captured after placement.

Winning:

- ♦ Black wins only on exactly five in a row; an overline (six or more consecutive stones) is a loss for Black.
- ♦ White wins on five or more in a row (overlines count as a win for White).

Forbidden moves for Black only:

- ♦ **Overline:** Black may not form six or more consecutive stones in a row.
- ♦ **Double-four:** Black may not place a stone that simultaneously creates two or more fours.
- ♦ **Double-three:** Black may not place a stone that simultaneously creates two or more open threes.

White has no forbidden moves. The asymmetric restrictions offset Black's first-move advantage.

OPENING RULES

Competitive Renju uses a special opening protocol to further balance the starting position. The current official rule for World Championships is Soosõrv-8 (adopted 2017). The Taraguchi-10 opening, used in earlier championships, proceeds as follows:

Move 1 (Black) is placed at the centre intersection. A swap option is available for either player after each of moves 1 through 4. Move 2 must be placed within the central 3×3 area; move 3 within the central 5×5; move 4 within the central 7×7.

After move 4, Black either continues (Branch A: place move 5 within the central 9×9, after which White has a swap option, then White plays move 6 anywhere) or offers ten alternative fifth moves anywhere on the board, no two symmetric, from which White selects one, then plays move 6 anywhere. After move 6, normal play resumes, with Black bound by forbidden-move restrictions.

STRATEGY

Under standard rules, unless one side makes a mistake by not blocking a closed four or open three, Black can only win through a four-three combination. White can win through four-three, three-three, four-four, or by forcing Black to make a forbidden move.

ATTRIBUTION

Competitive variant of Gomoku. Rules governed by the Renju International Federation. Public domain. The Renju International Federation was founded in Stockholm, Sweden on August 8, 1988.

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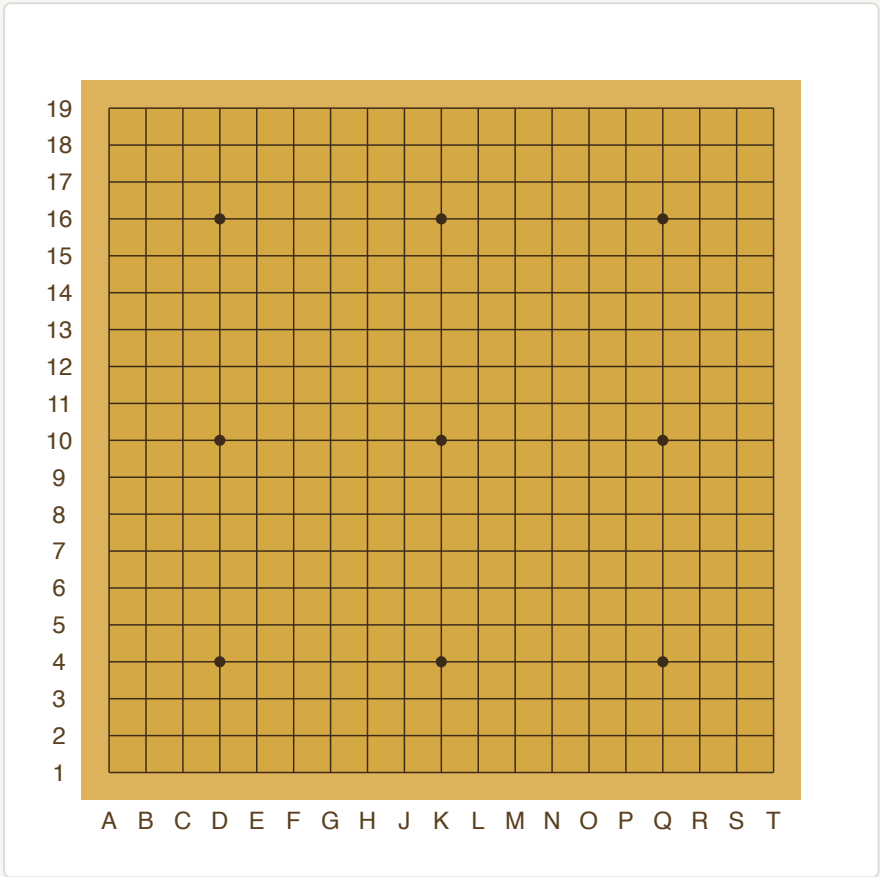
Stoical Go

19×19
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

STOICAL GO

A single rule addition transforms the game: you cannot capture opponent stones on any turn immediately following a turn where your opponent captured your stones. This forced restraint prevents immediate retaliation and creates a rhythm of attack and recovery unique to this variant.



Stoical Go — standard board

SETUP

Standard 19×19 board (or any size). Board starts empty. Black plays first. Standard komi.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply, with one addition:

- ♦ **Stoical restriction:** If your opponent captured one or more of your stones on their last turn, you may NOT make a capture on your next turn. You must play a non-capturing move (or pass).
- ♦ **Delayed response:** The restriction lasts only one turn. On your following turn, you may capture normally again.
- ♦ **Ko interaction:** The stoical restriction is separate from the ko rule. Both apply independently.

SCORING

Standard scoring (area or territory). Standard komi.

STRATEGY

The stoical restriction eliminates the back-and-forth capture exchanges that define much of standard Go tactics. When your opponent captures, you cannot immediately recapture or launch a counter-capture — you must wait a full turn. This means:

- ♦ Attacks become more committal. Once you capture, your opponent gets a free “safe” turn.
- ♦ Defence becomes stronger. A player under attack knows that after losing stones, they get one turn of guaranteed safety.
- ♦ Ko fights change dramatically. The usual ko threat/response cycle is disrupted by the stoical restriction.

ATTRIBUTION

Modern variant. Public domain. Source: Sensei’s Library.

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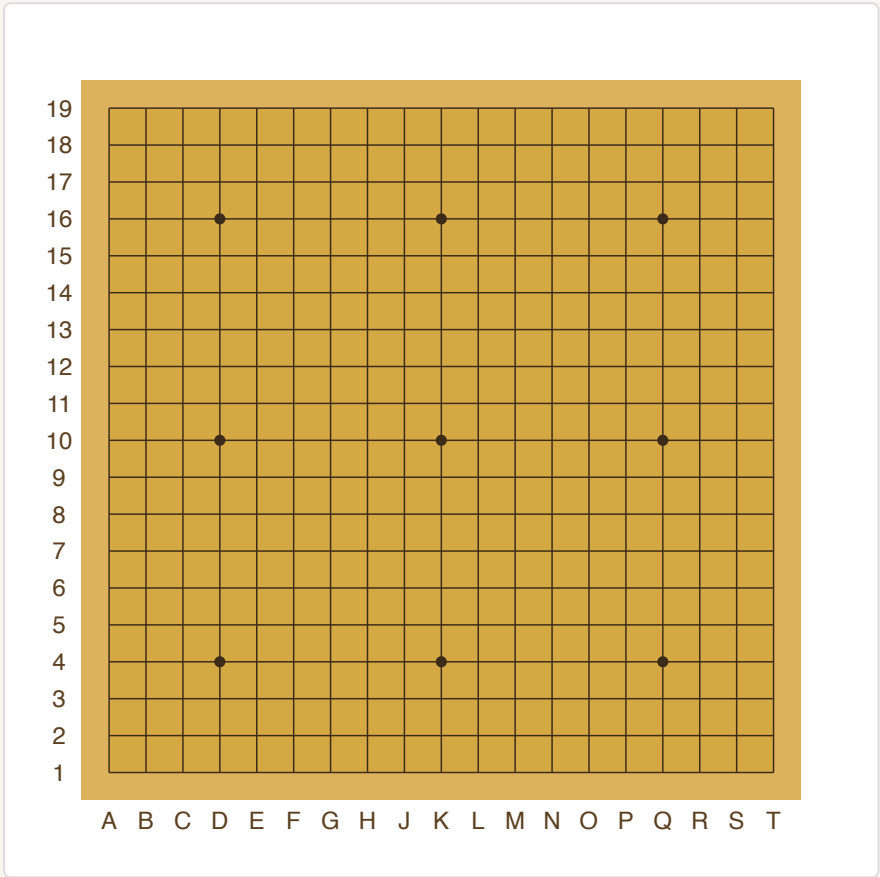
Sunjang Baduk

19×19
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

SUNJANG BADUK

Korea's historical form of Go (순장바둑), the dominant version played in Korea before Japanese rules were introduced in the early 20th century. Sixteen stones are pre-placed in a fixed diagonal pattern, prisoners are not counted in scoring, and there is no komi. This creates a radically different opening theory with immediate territorial frameworks from move one.



Sunjang Baduk — 19×19 with pre-placed stones

SETUP

Board: Standard 19×19 grid.

Pre-placed stones: 8 black stones and 8 white stones are placed before play begins, in fixed positions on the star points (4-4 intersections) and key approach points. The standard placement creates a diagonal symmetry.

First move: Black plays first. No komi (the pre-placed stones are considered balanced).

RULES

All standard Go rules apply with these modifications:

- ♦ **Capture scoring:** Captured stones are simply removed from the board. They do NOT count as prisoners and are NOT subtracted from the opponent's score. Only territory (surrounded empty intersections) is scored.
- ♦ **No komi:** The pre-placed symmetric position is considered fair. White receives no compensation.
- ♦ **Ko:** Standard ko rule.
- ♦ **Suicide:** Forbidden.

SCORING

Territory only: Score = empty intersections surrounded by your stones. Captures affect the board position (removing stones opens territory) but dead stones themselves have no point value.

STRATEGY

The pre-placed stones create immediate territorial frameworks. Opening theory revolves around how to exploit or undermine the pre-established positions. The lack of prisoner scoring means capturing stones is only valuable for the territory it reveals, not for the stones themselves. This discourages pointless capture races and rewards efficient territory-building.

ATTRIBUTION

Traditional Korean variant. Public domain. Historically the dominant form of Go in Korea until approximately 1920. Source: Wikipedia, Korean Baduk Association historical archives.

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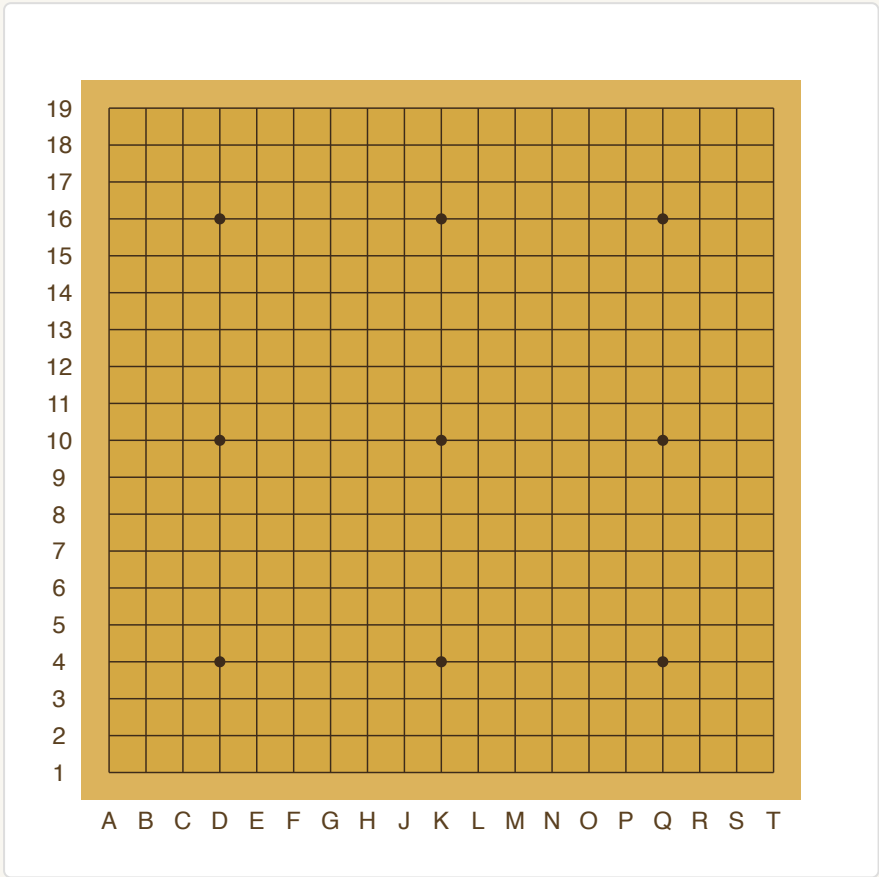
Tibetan Go

17×17
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

TIBETAN GO

Known as Mig Mang (མིག་མང, “many eyes”), this is Tibet’s indigenous Go variant with rules significantly different from Chinese Weiqi. Played on a 17×17 board with pre-placed stones, delayed captures, and a cosmological scoring system that awards points for territory, captures, and specific board positions.



Tibetan Go — played on 17×17 (shown on 19×19)

SETUP

- Board:** 17×17 grid (289 intersections).
- Pre-placed stones:** Before play begins, 6 white stones and 6 black stones are placed in fixed positions on the 4th-line star points (similar to handicap placement). The specific positions vary by tradition.
- First move:** Black plays first.

RULES

- ♦ **Placement:** Standard — one stone per turn on any empty intersection.

- ♦ **Liberties:** Same as standard Go — adjacent empty intersections.

Delayed capture: When a group loses its last liberty, it is NOT immediately removed. The opponent must play one more move

- ♦ to confirm the capture. If the surrounded group can connect to safety or gain a liberty before the confirming move, it survives. This gives the defender one extra chance.

- ♦ **Ko:** Standard ko rule applies.

- ♦ **Suicide:** Forbidden.

SCORING

Tibetan Go uses a unique additive scoring system:

- ♦ **Territory:** Empty intersections surrounded by your stones.

- ♦ **Prisoners:** Each captured stone scores points.

- ♦ **Position bonus:** Specific board patterns (eyes, living groups in corners) award additional points in some traditions.

The exact scoring weights vary by regional tradition. White receives compensation (equivalent to komi) for moving second.

STRATEGY

The delayed capture rule makes attacks less decisive: surrounding a group does not guarantee its death. This encourages peaceful coexistence and territory-building over aggressive fighting. The pre-placed stones shape the opening, creating a more symmetrical start than standard Go.

ATTRIBUTION

Traditional Tibetan game (Mig Mang). Public domain. Source: Wikipedia, academic ethnographic sources.

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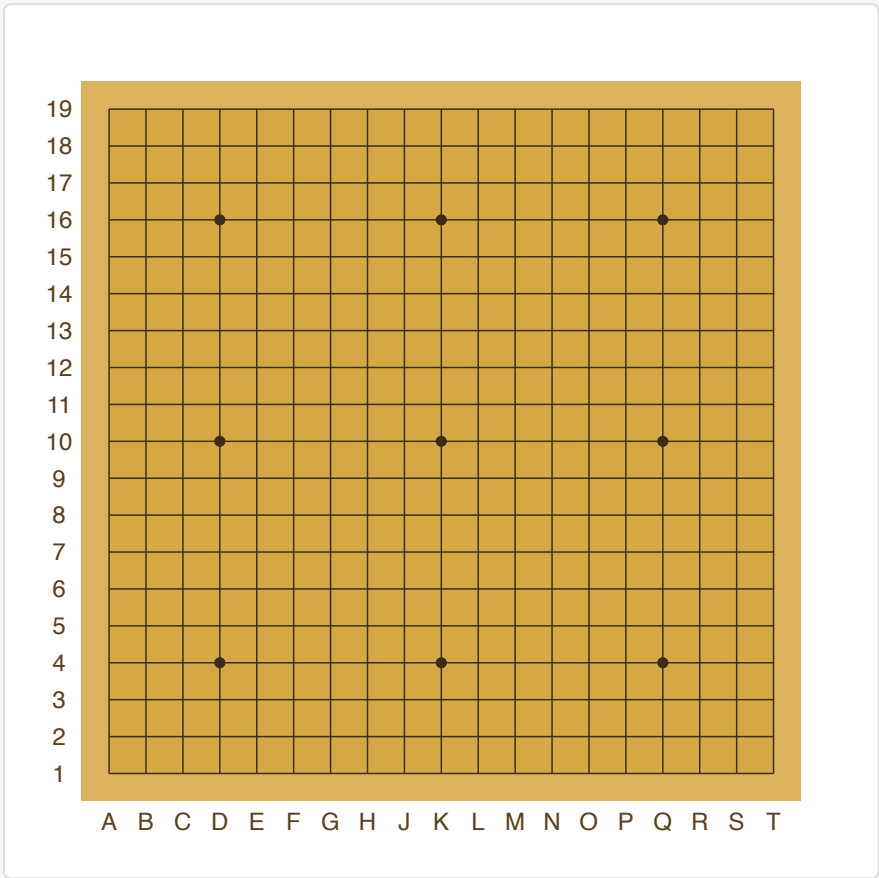
Toroidal Go

11×11
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

TOROIDAL GO

Standard Go played on a board where edges wrap around horizontally and vertically. No corners, no edges, no joseki. Every group floats. Active tournament community since 2012 with 1,400+ recorded games.



Toroidal Go — edges wrap (shown flat)

SETUP

Board: A grid where the far left connects to the far right, and the top connects to the bottom. Every intersection has exactly four neighbours. The standard size is 11x11, though 9x9 through 25x25 are also played.

Stones: Standard Go stones. Black plays first.

RULES

All standard Go rules apply (placement, capture by surrounding, ko rule, no suicide) with one modification:

- ♦ **Wraparound adjacency:** Each intersection on the far left is adjacent to the corresponding intersection on the far right. Each intersection on the top is adjacent to the corresponding intersection on the bottom. The surface is topologically a torus.
- ♦ **No edges or corners:** Every intersection has exactly four neighbours. There are no edge or corner positions anywhere on the board.
- ♦ **Scoring:** Standard area (Chinese) or territory (Japanese) scoring applies. White receives 4.5 komi on an 11x11 board.

STRATEGY

- ♦ All groups are floating from the opening move. Corner joseki (standard sequences) do not exist.
- ♦ Making two eyes to live is harder because there are no natural safe structures at board edges.
- ♦ Splitting the opponent into two separate eyeless groups and attacking one is a primary strategy.
- ♦ Territorial frameworks must be small on 11x11; forcing the opponent into thin shape is key.

VISUALISATION

Most software displays 3-4 extra lines around the main grid as duplicates of the opposite edges (shown in a different background colour). On a physical 19x19 board, 11x11 toroidal Go can be played using the inner 11x11 area with the outer lines serving as wraparound reference.

TOURNAMENT HISTORY

On LittleGolem, an ongoing ladder tournament has 21 players. A previous tournament ran from 2012 to 2020: 129 players, 1,497 games, 138 rounds, average 76 moves per game. The European Go Congress has hosted toroidal Go tournaments, most recently in 2023.

ATTRIBUTION

Variant with active competitive community. Source: Sensei's Library (OPL 1.0).